The television coverage of the Gulf War was the most extensive in the history of this medium. An analysis of the coverage reveals interesting data. Three out of every five statements (59 percent) regarding government policy about the war were negative. On the other hand, statements about the American soldiers and American weapons were generally positive. The results of the Times Mirror polls showed that more Americans participated in demonstrations in support of the war than in those that opposed it, but the media coverage of that period revealed that more coverage was given to antiwar demonstrations.

The most evident conclusion of the data arising from an analysis of the media is this: When there is a conflict between the media and the government, the public usually supports the media and their duty to fulfill the public's right to know. But when it comes to matters of life and death, the equation changes. In such a situation, the public prefers to censor some information in order to protect the lives of those who are protecting it. This conclusion raises the question: What about Israel? It would be correct to say, with some degree of generalization, that Israelis have been in living in a life-or-death situation since the establishment of the state, and we do not know any other reality. Therefore, the answer to the question of the need for censorship—not the institution but the concept—should be obvious.

Public opinion polls in the United States have for years pointed to two other negative aspects of the media: the arrogance of journalists and the mediocre level of professionalism. The public as a whole exhibits a negative attitude to the journalistic tendency to get a story at any price and to emphasize negative stories over positive stories. These days one can easily identify attitudes according to which the press is "them" versus the public that is "us." Within a generation, the image of the journalist in the United States has transformed from one of the poor and wretched soul fighting for his reputation through integrity and good values to one of the stereotypical rich and famous "celeb." There has been a distinct change from a culture in which the average person sees the journalist as someone who truly represents him or her to a culture in which the ordinary citizen feels alienated from the press.

In Israel, within a generation, we have witnessed a revolution from a press owned, operated, and mobilized by political parties to a commercial press whose outlets fight among themselves over small market shares in order to survive; for this purpose the ends justify the means, including